

20 per cent inside the baseline and from 55 to 33 per cent in exchanges more than six feet behind the baseline. The momentum reversals continued in the deciding set with each player breaking twice to force a tiebreak. Gauff belted a forehand winner on the first point to set the tone for the lopsided 7-2 breaker and finished off Zheng with a slice forehand approach winner.

No margin for errors

"The match today, it's just a couple of important points," rightly noted Zheng. "Nothing more to say. The match was very close, and then, you know, at the end, when you play this type of match, it's not about tennis, it's just about the choices on court." Zheng's poor shot selection, particularly reckless and wild errors, ultimately cost her the match.

"I was just telling myself — another point, another chance. I've been in situations like this in the past where I've been able to turn it around, and I was just hoping I could do it again today," said Gauff, who came back from two service breaks in the deciding set and hung tough to break back when Zheng served for the title at 5-4.

How Gauff and Zheng can challenge the Big Two

Sabalenka has earned the unofficial title of 'Queen of Hard Courts' by winning the last three Majors on that surface, while Świątek, the undisputed 'Queen of Clay', already boasts four French Open titles at just 23. However, neither has won Wimbledon nor even reached its final. Sabalenka has reached the semifinals twice, while Świątek's best result is a single quarterfinal appearance.

Gauff and Zheng will need to master different surfaces as well as their rivals. Both possess the athleticism, power, versatility, and competitiveness to win on any surface. However, in head-to-head records Świątek leads Gauff 11-2 (including 5-0 on clay), while Sabalenka holds a 5-0 advantage over Zheng, with four of those wins coming on hard courts this season.



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